

## **CRAC-Vitae**

### **Reforming Research Assessment – A Three Year COARA action plan – 2024 - 2026**

#### **Introduction to Vitae**

##### **Who we are**

The Careers Research and Advisory Centre (CRAC) is an independent and trusted provider of expertise on all aspects of careers in research. CRAC manages Vitae, a not-for-profit programme and sector leader in the professional and career development of researchers.

CRAC-Vitae has expertise in career tracking, research culture and researcher development and regularly leads large research projects, commissions and consultations in these areas.

We developed the Researcher Development Framework (RDF), an internationally recognised professional development tool that describes the knowledge, behaviour and attributes of successful researchers. We also developed the Research Culture Framework, which maps out the behaviours and values required for open, inclusive, and supportive working environments.

##### **Our vision**

Careers in research—across all sectors—are open, rewarding, and inclusive.

##### **Why this matters**

When all individuals are included and supported to succeed in their careers, research becomes more innovative, creative, and impactful.

##### **Our role**

- An independent and trusted provider of evidence on all aspects of careers in research.
- An advocate for the conditions that enable individuals to succeed in their careers in research, in any sector.

- A convenor, community builder, and collaborator, working in partnership with the sector to ensure that professional and career development is inclusive, relevant, and meaningful for all those involved in research.

### Our Values

- Inclusive
- Collaborative
- Informed by evidence
- Act with integrity

### Creating our Action Plan

We have considered our action plan against all ten of the COARA core commitments, however, it is clear that as we are not strictly a research performing organisation that certain commitments are more appropriate than others. Whilst we uphold all of the commitments and are committed to sharing knowledge, practice and expertise with our network and community, we are able to be more active in those commitments that support researchers and researcher development. We have therefore chosen to focus on **Commitments 5, 7, 8 and 9** as these are most aligned with our core researcher development and research culture frameworks.

We have developed our action plan from a number of perspectives, as an employer, on behalf of the Vitae community and the wider research ecosystem and environment.

### The Action Plan by Commitments

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| 1 Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in accordance with the needs and nature of the needs and nature of the research | It is important to note that Vitae as an organisation does not directly conduct any form of research assessment processes. |  |
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| <p><b>Purpose:</b> This commitment will broaden recognition of the diverse practices, activities and careers in research, considering the specific nature of research disciplines and other research endeavours</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How does your organisation plan to enable recognition of more diverse contributions to research?</li> <li>• How does your organisation plan to enable greater diversity in career paths and profiles?</li> </ul> | <p>We will adhere to the following principles in line with the core commitments of the COARA agreement. We will:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Encourage members and our community to consider reforming research assessment at Vitae events</li> <li>• Support efforts to raise the profile of non-traditional outputs through involvement in the Hidden REF.</li> <li>• Engage in discussions around the evolution of the REF 2029</li> <li>• Advocate for responsible transparent and sustainable assessment practices to our stakeholders and community.</li> <li>• Raise support for and build awareness of all COARA initiatives.</li> </ul> |  |
| <p>2 Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators</p> <p><b>Purpose:</b> This commitment will enable the move towards research assessment criteria that focus primarily on quality, while recognising that responsible use of quantitative indicators can support assessment where meaningful and relevant, which is context dependent.</p>                         | <p>It is important to note that Vitae as an organisation does not directly conduct any form of research assessment processes.</p> <p>We will adhere to the following principles in line with the core commitments of the COARA agreement. We will:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Encourage members and our community to consider reforming research assessment at Vitae events</li> <li>• Support efforts to raise the profile of non-traditional outputs through involvement in the Hidden REF.</li> <li>• Engage in discussions around the evolution of the REF 2029</li> </ul>                                                                  |  |

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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How does your organisation plan to actively engage in and learn from research on research work?</li> <li>• How does your organisation plan to accommodate qualitative evaluation mechanisms and base the use of metrics in a way that is aligned with your organisations value system?</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Advocate for responsible transparent and sustainable assessment practices to our stakeholders and community.</li> <li>• Raise support for and build awareness of all COARA initiatives.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |  |
| <p>3 Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment or journal and publication based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of journal impact factor and h-index</p> <p><b>Purpose:</b> This commitment will reduce the dominance of a narrow set of quantitative journal- and publication-based metrics.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How does your organisation plan to actively engage in and learn from research on research work?</li> <li>• How does your organisation plan to accommodate qualitative evaluation mechanisms and base the use of metrics in a way that is aligned with your organisations value system?</li> </ul> | <p>It is important to note that Vitae as an organisation does not directly conduct any form of research assessment processes.</p> <p>We will adhere to the following principles in line with the core commitments of the COARA agreement. We will:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Encourage members and our community to consider reforming research assessment at Vitae events</li> <li>• Support efforts to raise the profile of non-traditional outputs through involvement in the Hidden REF.</li> <li>• Engage in discussions around the evolution of the REF 2029</li> <li>• Advocate for responsible transparent and sustainable assessment practices to our stakeholders and community.</li> <li>• Raise support for and build awareness of all COARA initiatives.</li> </ul> |  |

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| <p>4 Avoid the use of rankings in research organisations in research assessment</p> <p><b>Purpose:</b> This commitment will help avoid that metrics used by international rankings, which are inappropriate for assessing researchers, trickle down to research and researcher assessment. It will help the research community and research organisations regain the autonomy to shape assessment practices, rather than having to abide by criteria and methodologies set by external commercial companies. This could include retaining control over ranking methodologies and data.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How does your organisation plan to mitigate reliance on organisation rankings?</li> </ul> | <p>It is important to note that Vitae as an organisation does not directly conduct any form of research assessment processes.</p> <p>We will adhere to the following principles in line with the core commitments of the COARA agreement. We will:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Encourage members and our community to consider reforming research assessment at Vitae events</li> <li>• Support efforts to raise the profile of non-traditional outputs through involvement in the Hidden REF.</li> <li>• Engage in discussions around the evolution of the REF 2029</li> <li>• Advocate for responsible transparent and sustainable assessment practices to our stakeholders and community.</li> <li>• Raise support for and build awareness of all COARA initiatives.</li> </ul> |                           |
| <p><b>5 Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to:</b></p> <p><b>Purpose:</b> This commitment will ensure that organisations allocate the necessary resources, whether in the form of budget or staff capacity, to improve research</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <p><b>Vitae to Co-Chair COARA the Working Group on Early and Mid Career Researchers. This working group focusses on understanding practice for early career researchers across Europe and highlights the main challenges and issues for this particular cohort. It will also act as a test group for other working groups and initiatives.</b></p> <p><b>Vitae are part of the COARA Boost programme which acts as secretariat as part of WP4 support for working</b></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <p><b>2024 – 2025</b></p> |

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| <p><b>assessment practices within their agreed timeframe.</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>Which resources will your institution allocate to the implementation of the research assessment reform? (capacity or budget)</b></li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <p><b>groups. . Vitae particularly support the TIER working group that considers gender bias in research assessment and the working group we also Chair on Early and Mid Career Researchers.</b></p> <p><b>Vitae are committed to the UK national chapter of COARA and considering research assessment reform from a national perspective through ongoing discussion and collaboration.</b></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | <p><b>2024 - 2026</b></p> <p><b>2024 - Ongoing</b></p> |
| <p>6 Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes</p> <p><b>Purpose:</b> This commitment will ensure that national / regional / organisational authorities and evaluation agencies review and, where needed, develop criteria for the assessment of research performing units and organisations, in accordance with the Principles. It will foster the responsible use of metrics in assessing research performing units and organisations, and help to prevent contradictions or incompatibilities between the assessment of research, researchers and research performing organisations. It will also safeguard the interoperability of adapted or newly developed assessment processes.</p> | <p>It is important to note that Vitae as an organisation does not directly conduct any form of research assessment processes.</p> <p>We will adhere to the following principles in line with the core commitments of the COARA agreement. We will:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Encourage members and our community to consider reforming research assessment at Vitae events</li> <li>• Support efforts to raise the profile of non-traditional outputs through involvement in the Hidden REF.</li> <li>• Engage in discussions around the evolution of the REF 2029</li> <li>• Advocate for responsible transparent and sustainable assessment practices to our stakeholders and community.</li> <li>• Raise support for and build awareness of all COARA initiatives.</li> </ul> |                                                        |

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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Does your organisation plan to pilot or implement alternative new assessment criteria, tools and processes (eg. Narrative CV, competency based CV, evidenced based CV format, diversification of research careers and associated career progression)</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                               |
| <p><b>7 Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use</b></p> <p><b>Purpose:</b> This commitment will ensure that organisations raise awareness of the reform among all actors. It will ensure that organisations transparently communicate the criteria, tools and processes used for research assessment and train researchers and assessors in their use.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Does your institution plan to provide training guidance and support to assessment panels committees and juries?</li> </ul> | <p><b>Vitae are committed to informing our member network through our member newsletter Vitae News (approx. 20,000 subscribers) and social media activity of relevant updates from COARA.</b></p> <p><b>Vitae are committed to reflecting COARA changes in their international conference programme and other policy events where appropriate.</b></p> <p><b>Vitae have considered reform in research assessment as part of their researcher development framework refresh and the framework has been revised in accordance. This will be further communicated and disseminated in our future work.</b></p> | <p><b>2024 – 2026</b></p> <p><b>2024 - 2026</b></p> <p><b>2024 - 2026</b></p> |

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| <p><b>8 Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the coalition</b></p> <p><b>Purpose:</b> This commitment will ensure organisations exchange and make use of information for mutual learning. It will help avoid fragmentation, contribute to the coherence of assessment practices between organisations, and enable researcher mobility. It also will allow those further ahead to share approaches and lessons learned, to benefit those who have further to go on their reform journey</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• How does your organisation plan to exchange practices and foster exchanges of good practices in national and international contexts?</li> </ul> | <p>Vitae have created a community which looks to improve the career and professional development of researchers. We are committed to drawing on this community to highlight and share practice in research assessment. This will be reflected in our member events as required.</p> <p>Vitae will continue to advocate for assessment practices that are responsible, transparent and sustainable through our events and member networks.</p> | <p>2024 – 2026</p> <p>2024 - 2026</p> |
| <p><b>9 Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the commitments</b></p> <p><b>Purpose:</b> This commitment will ensure organisations update one another on the progress made. It will foster careful self-reflection and monitoring of their own</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | <p>Vitae are committed to an annual review and short report on their progress against the COARA action plan. This will be reflected in our annual report with action plans required as necessary.</p> <p>Vitae are committed to contributing to key discussions including COARA general assembly, national chapter and working group leaders meetings.</p>                                                                                    | <p>2024 – 2026</p> <p>2024 – 2026</p> |



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| <p><b>adherence to the Principles and progress towards meeting the Commitments.</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>How will your organisation ensure the transparent communication of the organisations research evaluation processes within and outside of the organisation?</b></li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <p><b>Vitae are committed to maintaining an ongoing dialogue with all relevant stakeholders regarding the research assessment reform process.</b></p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | <p><b>2024 – 2026</b></p>                           |
| <p><b>10 Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state of the art in research on research and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research</b></p> <p><b>Purpose:</b> This commitment will ensure that assessment approach decisions are evidence informed. It will help organisations reflect on their own processes, gain understanding about whether assessment practices achieve the desired goals, and engage in evolutive assessment based on new evidence as it becomes available. It will also help to ensure control and ownership of research assessment data by the research community.</p> | <p><b>Vitae are a work package leader in the OPUS project which has developed a framework of indicators and interventions linking researcher assessment to open science. In the final year of the project we will continue to finalise this framework based on feedback and ensure that it is both comprehensive and accessible. A number of dissemination and communication activities be carried out as part of this including policy briefs. We will also consider how to ally with working group activity.</b></p> <p><b>On completion of the OPUS project Vitae will look to build on the framework through dissemination and communication activities and look to embed as part of COARA practice. We will look to seek opportunities to further leverage this.</b></p> | <p><b>2024 – 2025</b></p> <p><b>2025 – 2026</b></p> |

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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• <b>How does your institution plan to monitor and evaluate its assessment criteria, tools and processes? What will be the frequency? Who will be involved in the evaluation?</b></li> </ul> |  |  |
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***THIS ACTION PLAN WILL BE REVISED IN JANUARY 2026***